J. Fake Nutrition 2020; 32: 88-89 · doi:10.9999/fake.2020.044 · letter to the editor

Registration, funding and the dose-response model in Park and Singh (2019)

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To the editor: We read with interest the trial by Park and Singh of three daily doses of oral iron for fatigue in iron-deficient, non-anaemic adults (J. Fake Nutrition 2019; 31: 214-229, doi 10.9999/fake.2019.011). A trial that models fatigue as a function of dose is welcome, and we have three questions about its reporting.

First, the article says the protocol was registered before the first participant was enrolled but gives no registration number, so readers cannot compare the reported outcomes with the planned ones. We found what appears to be the trial in a public registry under FAKE-CTR-2016-0412.

Second, that registry entry lists Fake Pharma Ltd as the supplier of the study iron. The article's funding statement names only the Fake Foundation for Nutrition Research. Even when a supplier has no role in the analysis, readers should be told.

Third, and most important, we could not reconcile the dose-response slope in Table 3, 0.45 points per 10 mg (95% CI 0.30 to 0.60), with the arm means shown in Figure 3. Read from the figure, the difference in the fall in fatigue between the 20 mg and 60 mg arms suggests a slope closer to 0.3 points per 10 mg. We ask the authors to share the output of the mixed model behind Table 3, or the arm-level changes at week 12, so that readers can check the estimate.

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Authors' reply

We thank Drs Okonkwo and Lindgren for their careful reading. The registration number and the source of the iron sulphate should have been reported, and we have asked the journal to publish a correction adding both.

On the dose-response slope, values read from a figure of arm means are not a reliable guide to a slope estimated from a mixed model with all visits, baseline fatigue and sex as covariates. We have rechecked the model and stand by the estimate in Table 3. We will make the model output available to the journal on request.

Park, J., Singh, R.